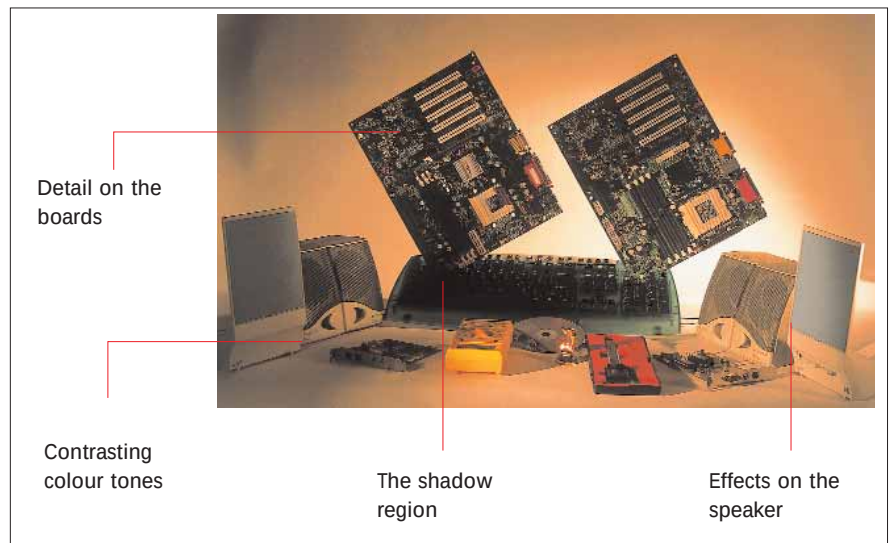


TEST PROCESS

The cameras were divided into two categories: cameras with resolutions above 1024x768 and those below it. These categories were decided upon keeping in mind that 1024x768 is a decent resolution that is clear enough on a monitor and in print-outs. We conducted two different tests on the cameras: the image quality and resolution test and the feature test. For the image quality test, we set up a target, which displayed elements such as gradation in shading, specular effect, colour tones, etc. The targets used were two motherboards, two speakers, a keyboard, graphics card and soundcard, a metal piece and a CD. In the resolution test we had a resolution chart, which was photographed from prespecified distances and the images were then tested on the PC to check how many blocks the camera detected.

Both the image quality and resolution test images were downloaded on to the computer and compared with the master image (main target image) taken with a regular 35 mm camera from the



same distance. In the feature test, the cameras were tested under different photography conditions for the onboard features they had. Apart from this, regular features such as flash, zoom lens, bundled software, storage media and accessories were also checked for.

The cameras that we tested belonged to brands that are currently available in India through dealers. After sales service and parts for these cameras are available through service centres in metro cities. The next five years should see digital cameras and printers become common peripheral devices, just like CDs and graphics cards. As PC penetration increases among both home and office segments, sales for digital cameras would also increase alongside.

Image test

The image quality test tells you about the overall quality of the camera, including its sensing element, lens and electronics that go into the making of a digital camera. Details: Out of the 13 cameras we tested, not many were able to detect small details. For instance, the net on the speakers appeared a light shade of grey and it was difficult to make out what it was made up of. Details are important during close-ups or when you are capturing items with fine details (such as when your girlfriend's dressed to kill). In this area we found that the Kodak DC-3400 picked up details better than any other camera. Not only was it able to pick the minute components on the motherboard, but also fonts as small as 12 points. The Kodak DC-4800 came second, although the image taken by this camera

was very grainy, which made it look very hazy. But the camera still picked up details such as the fonts on the chipset and the hole on the socket, which even the DC-3400 could not pick up.

Colour: In the colour reproduction test, Fuji gave the best results. This camera detected colour better than any other, but the overall image was slightly dark. Dark areas were also visible on the left side of the keyboard due to which the letters on the keys were not visible, since the amount of light projected in this area was kept low. In the real world, this simply means that if you were clicking an indoor photograph and if some parts of the frame contains lesser light than the others, the people in that area wouldn't be visible in the final image. And if one of them happens to be your wife, God help you!

Specular effect: In the specular effect test, the Olympus Camedia C-860L gave perfect results. The specular effect on the metal horse was reproduced as is. This was followed again by the Olympus Camedia 990 Zoom, which did well but suffered a bit in terms of the contrast, which was lesser than the C-860L. Among the cameras that had less than 1024x768 resolution, D-Link's Digi-Link gave good results in the specular effect test. This means that if you were clicking a photograph of your bald father-in-law, who is

standing under a bright 100 W bulb with its reflection on his shiny head, the photograph taken by either the Olympus Camedia C-860L or 990 Zoom would give you the best possible results as opposed to any other camera. The same is true for the low-end Digi-Link camera.

The final results of the image evaluation test showed that the **Kodak DC-4800** gave the best overall results in terms of detail, brightness and contrast, as well as image likeness, which was much closer to the actual situation created, than any other camera. It gave good results in terms of details and clarity but allowed more light into the picture than required in spite of keeping the setting on Auto.

On the other hand, the Fuji FinePix 2400 had the best colour detection and did pick the details to some extent



Canon Powershot: Okay performance